

How Mary Ann Shadd Cary Took Philadelphia by Storm in 1855

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First Black Woman to Start a Newspaper in North America

As the first Black woman to start a newspaper in North America, Mary Ann Shadd Cary worked as Editor, Publishing Agent, and Financier for *The Provincial Freeman*. She handled most writing, editing, sales, and financing herself. Though she excelled at the work, she sometimes described it as demanding "drudgery" requiring little rest. Travel conditions proved equally difficult—she endured freezing carriages and racist conductors while journeying "without a dollar." Despite these hardships, she persisted, famously writing that "The Freeman lived."

Born in the Philadelphia region, Shadd Cary witnessed her parents' Underground Railroad work in Delaware and Westchester, Pennsylvania. She developed two controversial positions: that Canada offered better prospects for Black Americans than the U.S., and that anti-slavery leadership needed more forceful tactics. In 1849, at age 26, she challenged Frederick Douglass's call for solutions, stating: "We have been holding conventions for years... and whining over our difficulties and afflictions. We should do more and talk less."

She later expanded these arguments in *A Plea for Emigration*, a 50-page treatise recommending where and how Black immigrants should settle in Canada. Her newspaper's motto—"Self-reliance is the True Road to Independence"—reflected her consistent advocacy for Black autonomy.

Rocking the 1855 Colored Convention

Though living in Canada, Shadd Cary attended the October 16, 1855 Colored Convention at Franklin Hall in Philadelphia. Among approximately 40 delegates, only two other women were present—Rachel Cliff and Elizabeth Armstrong. She was the sole Canadian delegate.

On the first day, her request to speak sparked what the article calls "spirited discussion"—code for significant disagreement. Frederick Douglass championed continuing the debate that evening at the Philadelphia Institute at 7th and Lombard. Douglass and Charles L. Reason, Principal of the Institute for Colored Youth, led supporters, while Isaiah C. Wears and Peter A. Bell opposed her participation. The vote favored admission 38 to 23.

Her 10-minute allotted time extended well beyond closing. According to historian Jane Rhodes, Shadd Cary "rocked the convention hall," leaving attendees "dazzled and awestruck" by her "masterly exposition."

Decisively Winning a Public Debate Generated from Her Ideas

Public interest led to a formal debate on November 5, 1855, between Shadd Cary and Isaiah C. Wears, an Underground Railroad leader who had voted against her convention admission.

Shadd Cary presented 12 arguments for Canadian emigration, emphasizing "the impartiality of the laws—the fine agricultural advantages—cheapness of the soil—health of the climate" and conditions for Black people specifically. Wears countered that mass emigration would abandon enslaved people and leave fugitives unprotected, strengthening their enemies.

Shadd Cary responded that rapid advancement in Canada, without ongoing U.S. oppression, would actually strengthen anti-slavery efforts. She cited Bishop Payne of Mother Bethel, unable to ride Philadelphia trolleys, while Canadian Black waiters rode "daily accommodated" without discrimination. She concluded that "the young colored man could enjoy" his rights "immediately" and become "a respectable and successful farmer, mechanic, or professional man in Canada."

Three male judges declared Shadd Cary the definitive debate winner.

Black Women Leaders Rally to Support Her

Recognizing Shadd Cary's need for financial support, Black women leaders organized a fundraising event at Shiloh Baptist Church for November 9, 1855. The organizing committee included Underground Railroad leaders and businesswomen Letitia Still and Henriette Duterte. Elizabeth Taylor Greenfield's church connection suggests her involvement, though records don't confirm her name.

Passmore Williamson, recently released from jail for assisting Jane Johnson's escape, was scheduled as a headliner but canceled last-minute. The women adjusted by securing Frederick Douglass and, crucially, Elizabeth Taylor Greenfield's volunteer services.

Greenfield, world-famous as a singer, volunteered her performances. Though scheduled for two songs, she performed a full concert, accompanied by two female pianists and a male singer. After multiple speakers addressed the packed, overflowing

crowd, the committee formally presented Shadd Cary with proceeds, confirming she deserved not only "their pecuniary aid but also to their fullest confidence and esteem."

Conclusion

Though revered in Canada with statues and murals, Mary Ann Shadd Cary's achievements in Philadelphia warrant greater recognition. In fall 1855, she "had beaten a man at a man's game and, in the process, enhanced her reputation as a powerful adversary in political matters." Within months, she became famous, disrupting misogyny, convincing a predominantly male convention, winning a public debate, and departing with fundraising proceeds for continued work.

Images

- Header of the Provincial Freeman with motto "Self-reliance is the true road to independence" — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_6ca9e84e0ccc443aafda090cc4c26259~mv2.png
- Title page of Mary Ann Shadd's pamphlet urging a move to Canada — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_638af67dcfcd44ada2ddb95d9b2bce98~mv2.png
- Frederick Douglass supported Mary Ann Shadd's speech at the 1855 Colored Convention — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_fcd65e3ed9d54620853ecc6a1fffaa66~mv2.png
- Professor Charles L. Reason supported Mary Ann Shadd's speech at the 1855 Colored Convention — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_45d6766cf58c4112bebbcc9be51b0e57~mv2.jpg
- Franklin Hall - site of the 1855 Colored Convention — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_f6bcd2610124464dbcaab4c7dfb8ee0a~mv2.gif
- AI re-imagining of the November 5, 1855 debate between Mary Ann Shadd and Isaiah C. Wears — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_886b626100b044d1ac38994b75991802~mv2.gif
- Henriette Duterte helped plan an event to support Mary Ann Shadd in 1855 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_a44bce1dd22c488d8f81e99854fffc81~mv2.jpg
- Elizabeth Taylor Greenfield sang at the event for free — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_74913a9116c14dceb3847f8d17292e65~mv2.jpg
- Still, William correspondence excerpt — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_d31adb4bff8a440185c78fded61e469b~mv2.jpg
- Still, William correspondence excerpt detail — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_e57fc7aee17a498e9030fec60f9a6afa~mv2.png
- Portrait of Mary Ann Shadd by Adeyemi Adegbesan outside Mackenzie House — no direct URL provided

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